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Indigenous Futurism in Meryl McMaster's *Ancestral* Photography Series

It is no doubt that media plays an integral role in forming worldviews, informing individuals and collectives, and serving as historical artifacts. With influence like this, it undoubtedly has had impact on society and cultural biases in relation to topics such as race, gender, sexuality, foreign affairs, and so much more. This is an example of Frantz Fanon's notion of invention, how concepts such race are invented, socially constructed (Fanon). Amiri Baraka's work compliments Fanon's by suggesting that just as things are invented, they can be re-invented or re-imagined. There are so many possibilities, that we should be questioning why things are the way that they are, who they were created for, and who is privileged by our inventions–especially inventions that are the norm or the default. *Afrofuturism* is representative of imagining alternate possibilities, ones that stray from settler colonial, White privileged systems and worldview that unfortunately are the default all over the world. Similar to Afrofuturism, Indigenous Futurism centers Indigenous culture, in a setting or medium that is futuristic and imaginative. It re-imagines something that is otherwise seen from a Euro-Centric, White-privileging lens, and instead creates it from an Indigenous, contemporary, futuristic perspective. From stylistic choices. to her subjects, to her artist's statement, McMaster created a piece that effectively dismantles Indigenous stereotypes and re-imagines them in an authentic, personal, futuristic manner.

Ancestry is a photographic series comprising of twelve photographs, each one a combination of nineteenth-century anthropologist, Edward Curtis's series entitled *The North American Indian* (1907-1930) layered with images of herself and her father. This layering method was done by painting the subjects entirely with white paint, making them a canvas to then have Curtis's original photos projected onto them. A couple of the images go beyond projecting the human form, being replaced by full colour-grade saturated images of a cougar and an eagle onto their bodies. The projections have a ghostly, glowing appearance, enhancing the effect of looking back in time that the old images evoke already. McMaster stated herself that her intent with this project was to reclaim her ancestor's identities and separate them from the skewed stereotype that Curtis promoted with the original photos (Meryl McMaster, Ancestral 1). While it is not the *most* futuristic setting amongst the genre of Indigenous Futurism, it is a piece of contemporary photography that certainly re-imagines Indigenous representation outside of the Amer-Euro lens using creative, dreamy, ambient and modern styling.



Top left to bottom right: McMaster, Meryl. *Ancestral 16*, *15*, *9*, *2*. 2008. Courtesty Pierre-François Ouellette Art Contemporain. (Meryl McMaster, Available Works).

The original photographs published by Edward Curtis are highly praised to this day, however it is also subject to critique for his romanticized portrayal of Indigenous Peoples that upholds stereotypes of a timid, "vanishing" population. This was during the time of Social Darwinism, when the reality of colonialism and assimilation were chalked up to be the natural fate of so-called "inferior" races. This fabricated idea popularized the genre of documentary photography, favored by anthropologists to be a method of preserving Indigenous Peoples around the world (Gascoigne). It is important to first understand what makes Curtis's original photographs problematic. Because of the series' anthropological and "preservative" intent, it is presented and assumed that the photos are candid and authentic. However, in reality, they were staged. They were staged with the intent to remove anything that could connotate to modernity or contemporary civilization. Cited examples of this include removing items like analog clocks or automobiles, and replacing them with pipes, tobacco, and other Indigenous paraphernalia (Gascoigne). Curtis also, more often than not, had his subjects change out of ordinary European and Western style clothing that they had adopted, into traditional Indigenous garments –many of which are typically saved for special and spiritual occasions (Smithsonian). Examples like this are critical in understanding how media artifacts such as photographs are manipulated and produced to uphold certain biases and agenda. It is particularly disturbing that this can occur even in academic fields such as anthropology, history, and other social sciences.



Curtis, Edward. *In a Piegan Lodge*. 1910. Courtesy of Photoethics.org.

Image above, showing Curtis's original image on the left, with a different photo published later in which the clock is removed.

One could argue that Curtis's photos are a step forward for Indigenous Peoples, as it appreciates their traditional garments and way of life. Still, the problem that persists with these images is firstly, that they were manipulated to portray a certain image of Indigenous Peoples and secondly, that these certain images are intended to make them look primitive and exotic,

as if they were frozen in a time prior to European colonial settlement (Meryl McMaster, Ancestral 1). It completely dismisses that Indigenous Peoples had evolved with modern times or experienced any sort of assimilation with European technology, clothing, et cetera. Of course, in the context of the time that these photos were taken, it may have seemed progressive, however nowadays it is difficult to see it as such upon considering questions of consent, authentic representation, consent, and active participation of Indigenous perspective.

Being of the visual art medium, there are very inherent and intentional stylistic choices that demonstrate McMaster's re-creation and re-imagination of her family's heritage and culture, presenting us with a piece of Indigenous Futuristic expression. The contrast between Curtis's original photographs in sepia colour grade, and her own projections that use a combination of subdued cool tones effectively juxtapose the two timelines. In 2010, McMaster added an extension to the series and projected images of animals onto human subjects, rather than old photos like Curtis's. These additional images create an evolution through time, just as the preceding photographs did. *Eagle* and *Cougar* seem like a continuation of the present timeline that McMaster created as a re-imagination of Curtis's photos, paying homage to her ancestry and culture. These two (among a few others in the extension) are much more saturated and clear than the rest of them, further bringing them into present and separating Indigenous culture from stereotyped representations like Curtis's. The effect of projecting and overlapping these juxtaposing photos creates a simultaneous contrast and connection between them. This serves to both connect and divide the past and the present, and perhaps in this act of re-imagining the past, even prompts the viewer to imagine the future. By projecting the photographs onto her and her father's bodies, McMaster creates an interactive and performance piece, bringing it to life and in a sense, really capturing Baraka's ideas of futurism as well as Fanon's writings of invention and re-imagination. What better canvas to evoke imagination and possibility, than a human themselves? The literal personification of the images not only serves to re-imagine and re-represent her ancestors, but also brings them to life, and gives them new possibilities in a futuristic but also humble and candid way.



Left: McMaster, Meryl. Eagle. 2010. Courtesy of Pierre-François Ouellette Art Contemporain.

Right: McMaster, Meryl. Cougar. 2010. Courtesy of Pierre-François Ouellette Art Contemporain. (Gismondi).

Connections can be made between *Ancestry* and writings by two scholars, Amiri Baraka and Frantz Fanon. Firstly, Fanon's distinction that race is invented as a social construct; just as it is an invention, so are the racist biases based upon it, and representations in media that support those biases. For example, Edward Curtis's nineteenth-century photographs. Since Whiteness has been made the default, anything else is left as marginalized to some degree. Marginalized groups of Black, POC, and Indigenous Peoples are left to either be abused and/or fetishized. They are othered. One example of this would be Orientalism, in which Middle Eastern and Asian people are represented in media (television, literature, film, historical representations, news, etc.) as exotic and submissive. In the case of *The North American Indian*, Curtis strategically produced and manipulated the medium of photography in order to capture the European-invented otherness of Indigenous Peoples, by perpetuating dated and inaccurate stereotypes that neglected the consent and participation of its subjects. To this day, many do not understand the problematic aspect of these iconic and aesthetically beautiful images, but it is important to reflect on how systemic racism is not always necessarily overt mistreatment or prejudice, but equally oppressive stereotyping and othering. As Fanon–and other anthropologists such as Signithia Fordham (Fordham, 2)– points out, Black people are expected to 'act White' in order to become successful. The alternative to this would be to play into

stereotypes that, on the surface may seem non-harmful or even celebratory, however do continue to perpetuate systemic racism and oppression through fetishization and otherness.

McMaster's *Ancestry* can be connected to the concepts of Indigenous Futurism, Fanon's ideas of the invention of race and White superiority, and Baraka's concept of multiple possibilities and Afrofuturism. Through stylistic choices, intent, and implied commentary, McMaster is able to convey Indigenous Futurism while intertwining the past and the present of Indigenous representation and identity. McMaster uses contrasting colour grades, lighting, projection, and subjects themselves to bring authentic Indigenous culture out of dated, stereotyped representations from the nineteenth century. It also aligns with Baraka's concept of Afrofuturism in that it puts the subject, Indigenous Peoples, in the position of "inventor-creator" (Baraka). Understanding the relationship between Fanon's argument that race and systemic racism is a human invention, and how media can be manipulated to represent perpetuating biases, is critical in analyzing any text. The futuristic interpretation from this series is nothing utopian or science-fiction, rather the way that it effectively plays with different timelines and re-creates images–stereotypes–from the past into something that reclaims Indigenous autonomy.

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